

Christian Wolff's Ethics of Enlightenment

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In this paper, I'd like to present Christian Wolff's universal practical philosophy as an ethics of enlightenment. While not a household name in Enlightenment philosophy compared with figures such as Locke, Voltaire, Rousseau, Hume, and Kant, Wolff was immensely popular in his time. In order to provide context, I'll first sketch Wolff's biography (§1). Next, I discuss the influence and impact of his works (§2). I then introduce the discipline of universal practical philosophy (§3), and show that it should be understood as an ethics of enlightenment (§4).

1. Christian Wolff's Life

Christian Wolff (1679–1754) was born in Breslau (modern-day Wrocław, Poland), the capital of the historical region of Silesia. Raised in a devout Lutheran household, Wolff developed an interest in mathematics and algebra and was first introduced to Cartesian philosophy. This early environment was formative for Wolff's later approach to philosophy. Surrounded by disputes between Lutherans and Catholics, Wolff found in the certainty of mathematics the promise of ending these controversies.

Wolff began his university studies in Jena in 1699. Although originally studying for a degree in theology, he soon began studying mathematics and philosophy as well. Wolff eventually transferred to Leipzig, where he sat the *Magisterexamen* in 1702 and defended his *Habilitationsthesis* in 1703, entitled *Philosophia practica universalis mathematica methodo conscripta*, a highly original work that established the discipline of *universal practical philosophy*, which was to be the foundation for every other part of practical philosophy (ethics,

politics, and economics). The habilitation also illustrates a signature feature of Wolff's philosophy that persists throughout all his later writings, namely the mathematical method, which involves clearly defining all of one's terms and demonstrating proofs on this basis.

Completing the habilitation allowed Wolff to work as a *Privatdozent* at the University of Leipzig for the next few years, where he taught mathematics, theology, and philosophy. Wolff stayed in Leipzig until Saxony was invaded by Swedish forces in 1706, an event that prompted students and professors to flee. With Leibniz's help, he was offered the chair of mathematics at the recently founded university in Halle. Wolff accepted, delivering his inaugural lecture there in January 1707.

Wolff was a popular and successful lecturer because he opted to lecture in German rather than in Latin, thereby making the lectures more accessible. Wolff initially lectured on mathematics but from 1709 onward, he also began lecturing on metaphysics, logic, and moral philosophy. During these productive years in Halle, tension began to build between Wolff and his colleagues. Wolff's principal opponent was the theologian Joachim Lange, a leading Pietist who was both jealous of Wolff's success and opposed to his views on issues relating to reason and revelation.

Indeed, Wolff's German works make it clear that philosophy should no longer be regarded as a mere handmaiden to theology but should rather be viewed as the most fundamental discipline. Thus, it is not surprising that Wolff's theological colleagues accused him of atheism, determinism, and Spinozism. The conflict came to a head on July 12, 1721. When handing over the office of pro-rector to Lange, Wolff delivered a speech entitled *Oratio de Sinarum philosophia practica*, in which he argued that the ancient Chinese developed a perfectly plausible theory of morality based on reason alone, without the help of divine revelation.

As a result of this lecture, the theological faculty petitioned officials in Berlin to investigate Wolff's writings for blasphemy, convincing King Friedrich Wilhelm I that Wolff was an atheist and determinist. On November 8, 1723, Wilhelm I issued a decree, stripping Wolff of his professorship and ordering him to leave Prussia within forty-eight hours on penalty of death by hanging.

Between 1727 and 1734, Wolff's philosophy was banned in Prussia. But this neither disheartened him nor signaled victory for his opponents. On the contrary, Wolff's expulsion from Prussia made him a martyr of the Enlightenment and served only to increase his fame across Europe. After fleeing Halle, Wolff went to Marburg, where he became professor.

Wolff remained in Marburg for seventeen years. After he was elected as one of only eight new members of the Parisian Royal Academy of Sciences in 1733, Wilhelm I questioned his expulsion of Wolff, asking him to return in November 1733; Wolff declined. In the summer of 1739, Wolff declined an offer of a professorship in Frankfurt an der Oder from Wilhelm I. On May 31, 1740 Wilhelm I died, and his son, Friedrich Wilhelm II (Frederick the Great) ascended the throne. One of Frederick the Great's first orders was to invite Wolff back to Prussia, and on September 10, 1740, Wolff was named vice-chancellor and professor of mathematics, natural law, and civil law in Halle.

In 1741, Frederick the Great made Wolff the curator of all Prussian universities and in 1743 he became the chancellor of the university of Halle. Wolff was made a baron in 1745, and in 1752 he was elected to the Academy of Sciences in Bologna. Wolff died in Halle on April 9, 1754, aged 76 years.

2. The Influence and Impact of Wolff's Philosophy

Wolff's philosophy was profoundly influential during the eighteenth century. For many decades, "Wolffianism" was the dominant philosophy at German-speaking universities. Professors who subscribed to Wolff's teachings held influential positions at major German universities, including Jena, Halle, Göttingen, Leipzig, and Königsberg. Wolff's philosophy continued to be influential into the late eighteenth century via the writings of his students and followers.

Both Wolff's theoretical philosophy *and* his practical philosophy held influential sway. Indeed, universal practical philosophy would prove to be momentous not only for Wolff's disciples but also for his critics and the so-called "popular" philosophers. Popular philosophy was an eclectic movement in eighteenth-century Germany, which was based (to varying degrees) on the philosophies of Leibniz and Wolff, on the one hand, and Locke, on the other. Notable adherents of this movement who advocated modified versions of universal practical philosophy include Johann Georg Heinrich Feder, Johann Paul Sutor, and Johann Georg Sulzer, alongside others broadly working under the Wolffian influence, such as Christian Garve and Christoph Meiners. Significantly, Christian August Crusius, an outspoken critic of Wolff, also called the foundation of his own moral system "universal practical philosophy" (*allgemeine praktische Philosophie*). While the details of its many expositions differ, Wolff's vision of universal practical philosophy as a foundational discipline of practical philosophy in general had become a reality.

This influence extended well beyond the height of Wolffianism as the dominant school in the earlier half of the eighteenth century. In the latter half of the eighteenth century, renowned figures such as Johann Augustus Eberhard, Johann Friedrich Flatt, and Johann Christoph Schwab resisted Kant's Critical philosophy under the banner of Leibniz and Wolff. Moreover, journals were created to counter the vanguard of Kantianism: the *Philosophisches Magazin* and

Philosophisches Archiv were largely devoted to denouncing the Critical philosophy from a Leibnizian–Wolffian perspective.

Wolff's influence during the eighteenth century also extended beyond the universities of the German-speaking areas. One of Wolff's most important influences was on the German language itself. Wolff's works were also translated into nearly every major European language during the eighteenth century. For instance, the *German Logic* was translated into seven languages, with scholars spreading his philosophy through the Netherlands, Spain, and Portugal, as well as Turkey and Greece. Moreover, Diderot's and d'Alembert's *Encyclopédie* was in many ways inspired by Wolff's philosophy. Indeed, many of its articles include material taken from the work of Wolff and his followers, such as that on natural law and moral philosophy. Not only this, but the titles of Wolff's works are listed in the library catalogues of all the oldest universities on the East coast of the United States, with many of the founding fathers, including Thomas Jefferson, owning copies of Wolff's works.

3. Universal Practical Philosophy

Universal practical philosophy concerns “the universal theory and praxis of philosophy” (Disc. §70), laying the foundation for defining the key concepts and principles common to all the practical disciplines (ethics, politics, economics).

Once such principle is the the universal rule that governs human conduct, that is, the law of nature: “do that which makes you and your state or that of another more perfect, omit that which makes it more imperfect” (DE §12). Based on key concepts such as *obligation* and *perfection*, the law of nature plays an indispensable role in Wolff's subsequent doctrine of duties.

It constitutes the major premise of two practical syllogisms that correspond to duties of performance and of omission, respectively:

We should do that which makes our state or that of others more perfect.

This action makes our state or that of others more perfect.

Therefore, we should do it.

We should omit that which makes our state or that of others more imperfect.

This action makes our state or that of others more imperfect.

Therefore, we should omit it. (DE §14)

These syllogisms ground the derivation of duties. But before turning to the doctrine of duties, let us consider a few more facets of Wolff's universal practical philosophy and its nuance.

Wolff also emphasizes the importance of conscience, that is, “the judgment about whether our actions are good or evil” (DE §73). Significantly, Wolff claims that the law of nature can also be called a *law of conscience* (DE §137), because conscience is necessary for acting in accordance with the law of nature: in order to conform our actions to the law of nature, we must *judge* whether they are good or evil. Moreover, Wolff's account of conscience offers insight into his moral psychology. Drawing on scholastic distinctions between varieties of conscience—antecedent, consequent, correct, certain, probable—Wolff sheds light on how moral judgment plays a significant role in our lived moral experience. Human beings are finite and fallible and thus liable to make incorrect moral judgments and to be in doubt about the right thing to do. Wolff's conception of conscience therefore helps to explain moral transgressions.

The highest good—which is also characterized as beatitude, or bliss (*Seeligkeit*)—is set out in the third chapter of Part I and consists in “unhindered progress toward greater perfections” (DE §44). This is correlated with happiness, which accordingly (in a seeming nod to the scholastics) connects happiness with virtue, i.e., the “habit of regulating one’s actions according to the law of nature” (DE §64).

These concepts form the foundation of Wolff’s ethics, or doctrine of duties, consisting of duties to self, duties to others, and duties to God.

4. Ethics of Enlightenment

Given that the law of nature obligates the promotion of perfection, at its core virtue amounts to the habit of promoting perfection (DE §65), which *ipso facto* entails the highest good (DE §68) and makes one happy (DE §66). This constellation is important for several reasons.

First, it displays Wolff’s appropriation of the Aristotelian connection between virtue and happiness within his own ethical framework. Second (and a programmatic part of the Enlightenment more broadly), it relates to Wolff’s aim of carving the leading edge of a pathway to human virtue and respectability (DE *Vorrede*, *2–3). This explains Wolff’s self-proclaimed status as a beacon of hope sent to edify the masses: “The definitions I have given of virtue and vice, and of good and evil actions, are a light which enlightens human beings, that they may see the truth” (DE *Vorrede*, *3).

Wolff takes his moral philosophy to serve as a beacon of light by virtue of its universality. Indeed, he claims “I have provided a universal concept of obligation the likes of which was previously not to be had” (AN §137). Thus, the law of nature “applies to all free actions” (DE §14) and is therefore “universal” (DE §§12, 14).

Furthermore, what is commanded by the law of nature is universally cognizable. Because human beings are capable of distinct cognition (although not completely distinct cognition), natural obligation is *knowable* through the proper use of the powers of the soul. Hence epistemic access to the law of nature and the particular laws of natural obligation derived from it is provided by our rationality: “reason teaches us what we ought to do and omit—that is, reason is the teacher of the law of nature” (DE §23)

Moreover, Wolff’s *Vernünfftige Gedancken von der Menschen Thun und Lassen, zu Beförderung ihrer Glückseeligkeit* is paradigmatic of enlightenment moral philosophy. It was the first systematic treatment of ethics in German; before Wolff, only Christian Thomasius had published works on moral philosophy exclusively in German (e.g., see *Einleitung zur Sittenlehre*, published in 1692 and *Ausübung der Sittenlehre*, published in 1696). And, yet, Thomasius’s moral philosophy was explicitly unsystematic—both linguistically and philosophically. Even Leibniz did not write a systematic treatise on ethics such that his views on the subject are scattered throughout his corpus. Wolff’s *German Ethics* therefore stands at the forefront of German Enlightenment moral philosophy.

Indeed, the book’s eight editions would profoundly shape the intellectual landscape of eighteenth-century Germany in several ways. First, it established a stable and systematic vocabulary for German practical philosophy. Second, Wolff’s framework of ethics would be adopted by generations of followers, coming to represent the dominant philosophical school in Germany for the greater part of the eighteenth century. Third, Wolff’s ethics would serve as an important foil for Kant’s practical philosophy, which stands opposed to Wolff’s on a number of core issues such as freedom, moral motivation, the supreme principle of morality, and duty.